

Monday, 18 May 2026.

Your daily radio show prep — three top news stories, forward-looking showbiz, sport that matters this week, talkback prompts, and day notes for today and tomorrow. Built fresh every weekday, ready by 3pm for tomorrow's show.

00 — WEATHER

Tomorrow's forecast

LONDON

Light drizzle

14° 9°

BIRMINGHAM

Rain

14° 8°

MANCHESTER

Light rain

15° 8°

GLASGOW

Light drizzle

14° 8°

01 — NEWS

Today's top stories

1

How Rayner, Streeting and Burnham weakened PM in 12 hours of political drama.

Three interventions by three senior Labour politicians made for an unforgettable day in British politics.

POLITICS · UK

2

Watch: Soldier on parachuting to remote island to bring Hantavirus aid.

A specialist team helped supply critical medical support to Tristan da Cunha in the South Atlantic.

UK · NEWS

3

North of England Olympic bid for 2040s being assessed.

The government has commissioned UK Sport to conduct an "initial strategic assessment" into a potential bid for the north of England to host the Olympics and Paralympics in the 2040s.

UK · NEWS

02 – SHOWBIZ

What's coming up

1

Soprano Dame Felicity Lott dies aged 79.

The British operatic soprano recently told the BBC of her terminal cancer diagnosis.

SHOWBIZ · UK

2

The 'prince of pop art who was forgotten by his home' city finally gets exhibition.

Peter Phillips was key to the pop art movement but his home city of Birmingham hardly noticed.

SHOWBIZ · UK

3

Search for new James Bond officially kicks off as auditions begin.

Callum Turner, Jacob Elordi and Harris Dickinson are among the frontrunners to replace Daniel Craig.

SHOWBIZ · UK

On the schedule

- 1 The Alonso dream is over - but Salah's outburst keeps heat on Slot.**
Xabi Alonso may now be heading to Chelsea, but Mohamed Salah's outburst keeps the pressure on Arne Slot, writes Phil McNulty.
SPORT · UK
- 2 Tipped for relegation to title winners - AGF's 'King Arthur' moment.**
Aarhus GF were tipped for relegation from the Danish Superliga this season. Instead, they will lift the championship trophy for the first time in 40 years this Sunday.
SPORT · UK
- 3 'Come get us' - England ready for Six Nations decider.**
A 38th straight Test win and eighth successive Six Nations title are far from formalities as patched-up England face rejuvenated France in a Grand Slam decider in Bordeaux.
SPORT · UK
- 4 No trophy in turbulent season but Alonso arrival offers Chelsea hope.**
From the gloom of an FA Cup final loss amid a turbulent campaign, Xabi Alonso's arrival gives Chelsea hope, writes Nizaar Kinsella.
SPORT · UK

Quick hits

- 1 Cash is making a small comeback — ATM withdrawals are up 14% on this time last year.**
Bank analysts credit budget-conscious households using cash to stay disciplined. The 'envelope method' is back trending on TikTok.
- 2 Loneliness is now considered a bigger health risk than smoking 15 cigarettes a day, according to NHS England.**
Social prescribing — GPs referring patients to community activities — is rolling out nationwide. Walking groups, book clubs and choirs are reportedly oversubscribed.
- 3 Almost 70% of UK households now have a smart speaker — but the most common use is still 'asking what time it is'.**
Researchers say we under-use the devices we own. Setting timers, playing music and weather queries make up two thirds of all commands.
- 4 Brits spend an average of 38 minutes a day deciding what to watch — and 12 of those are spent scrolling Netflix.**
'Watch-paralysis' has its own subreddit. Streamers are quietly experimenting with 'shuffle' buttons that just play something.
- 5 Roses are out, peonies are in — UK florists report a 200% rise in peony orders for weddings this summer.**
Brides cite 'softer, less staged' aesthetics. Wholesale peony prices have crept up accordingly.
- 6 The 'silver gamer' is the fastest-growing demographic in UK gaming — over-65s spent £180 million on games last year.**
Cosy life-sim titles like Stardew Valley and Animal Crossing dominate. Console makers are reportedly designing larger UI for the market.
- 7 One in three of us has had a 'sleep divorce' — sleeping in a separate bed from our partner.**
Reasons: snoring (45%), different schedules (30%), restless legs, and one bizarre 12% who say their partner 'talks to the cat in their sleep'.

05 – TALKBACK

For the phone lines

OUR SURVEY SAID

Q 71% of us admit to doing **THIS** in the car when we think no-one is watching. What is it?
ANSWER: SINGING AT THE TOP OF OUR LUNGS, WITH FULL DRAMATIC FACIAL EXPRESSIONS.

Q Asked 'what's the most British thing about your morning?', the number one answer wasn't a cup of tea — it was **THIS**.
ANSWER: APOLOGISING TO SOMEONE WHO WALKED INTO YOU.

TALK TOPIC

- **A new study says we form a strong opinion of someone within 7 seconds of meeting them.**
Talk-back: what's the quickest you've ever decided you didn't like someone — and were you right? Or the quickest you DID like someone?
- **Matching pet-and-owner outfits are apparently making a comeback this summer.**
Would you actually do it? And if so — does the dog get a vote in the wardrobe?

TRUE STORY OR JACKANORY – LISTENERS GUESS

FACT **UK News.** A council in the North-West has agreed to fix a much-complained-about pothole only after a resident planted a small tree in it and the photo went viral. The pothole had been reported 17 times in a year before the tree solved it overnight.

FICTION **Made up, but believable.** A Devon village has voted unanimously to ban Vinted couriers from parking on its narrow high street, after a single delivery driver knocked over the same pub's hanging basket three weeks in a row.

06 – LOTTERY

Jackpots ahead

NEXT EUROMILLIONS JACKPOT

£8.35 million

Next Tuesday or Friday · estimated

NEXT NATIONAL LOTTERY JACKPOT

£8.35 million

Next Wednesday or Saturday · estimated

07 – FACTS OF THE DAY

Did you know?

- Sharks existed before trees. Sharks have been around for 400 million years; trees only 350 million.
- Bubble wrap was originally invented as wallpaper. It flopped, so they pivoted to packaging.
- There are more stars in the universe than grains of sand on every beach on Earth.
- A group of flamingos is called a flamboyance.
- The shortest war in history was between Britain and Zanzibar in 1896 — it lasted 38 minutes.
- Your stomach gets a new lining every three to four days. Otherwise it would digest itself.
- The first message ever sent on the internet was 'LO' — they were trying to type 'LOGIN' but the system crashed.
- An ostrich's eye is bigger than its brain.

On this day

Day 138 of the year, 227 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Ælfgifu of Shaftesbury; Christian feast day: Blessed Blandine Merten; Christian feast day: Eric IX of Sweden; Christian feast day: Felix of Cantalice. Star sign Taurus, birthstone Emerald.

TODAY'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1948 — Joe Bonsall, American country/gospel singer (died 2024)
- 1958 — Toyah Willcox, English singer-songwriter, producer, and actress
- 1982 — Jason Brown, English footballer
- 2000 — Steven Sessegnon, English footballer
- 2009 — Hala Finley, American actress
- 1970 — Tina Fey, American actress, producer, and screenwriter
- 1942 — Nobby Stiles, English footballer, coach, and manager (died 2020)
- 1952 — George Strait, American singer, guitarist and producer

THE DAY TODAY

- 1974 — Nuclear weapons testing: Under project Smiling Buddha, India successfully detonates its first nuclear weapon becoming the sixth nation to do so.
- 1980 — Students in Gwangju, South Korea begin demonstrations calling for democratic reforms.
- 1955 — Operation Passage to Freedom, the evacuation of 310,000 Vietnamese civilians, soldiers and non-Vietnamese members of the French Army from communist North Vietnam to South Vietnam following the end of the First Indochina War, ends.

TODAY IN MUSIC

- 1944 — World War II: Battle of Monte Cassino: Conclusion after seven days of the fourth battle as German paratroopers evacuate Monte Cassino.
- 1969 — Apollo program: Apollo 10 is launched.

TODAY IN HISTORY

- 1965 — Israeli spy Eli Cohen is hanged in Damascus, Syria.
- 2018 — Cubana de Aviación Flight 972 crashes in Santiago de las Vegas after takeoff from José Martí International Airport in Havana, Cuba, killing 112 of the 113 people on board.

- 1980 — Rioting spreads to Miami's mostly African-American neighborhoods of Overtown and Liberty City following the previous day's courthouse protests.

A peek at tomorrow

Day 139 of the year, 226 days left in 2026. Today Christian feast day: Calocerus (Eastern Orthodox Church); Christian feast day: Crispin of Viterbo; Christian feast day: Dunstan (Roman Catholic Church, Eastern Orthodox Church; commemoration, Anglicanism); Christian feast day: Ivo of Kermartin. Star sign Taurus, birthstone Emerald.

TOMORROW'S BIRTHDAYS

- 1965 — Maile Flanagan, American actress, producer, and screenwriter
- 1956 — Martyn Ware, English keyboard player, songwriter, and producer
- 1992 — Heather Watson, British tennis player
- 1970 — Stuart Cable, Welsh drummer (died 2010)
- 1983 — Jessica Fox, English actress
- 1961 — Gregory Poirier, American director, producer, and screenwriter
- 1968 — Kyle Eastwood, American actor and bass player
- 1941 — Nora Ephron, American director, producer, and screenwriter (died 2012)

THE DAY TOMORROW

- 2012 — Three gas cylinder bombs explode in front of a vocational school in the Italian city of Brindisi, killing one person and injuring five others.
- 1991 — Croatians vote for independence in a referendum.
- 1997 — The Sierra Gorda biosphere, the most ecologically diverse region in Mexico, is established as a result of grassroots efforts.

TOMORROW IN MUSIC

- 1963 — The New York Post Sunday Magazine publishes Martin Luther King Jr.'s Letter from Birmingham Jail.
- 1991 — Croatians vote for independence in a referendum.

Coming to cinemas

MAY 2026

FRI 15	Mortal Kombat II (+ IMAX); Is God Is; Poetic License
FRI 22	The Mandalorian and Grogu (+ IMAX)

JUNE 2026

FRI 5	Masters of the Universe; Power Ballad
FRI 12	Scary Movie 6; new Spielberg film (+ IMAX)
FRI 19	Pixar's Toy Story 5
FRI 26	Supergirl: Woman of Tomorrow (+ IMAX); A Private Life

JULY 2026

WED 1	Minions & Monsters
FRI 3	Shiver; Young Washington
FRI 10	Moana (live action); Evil Dead Burn
FRI 17	Christopher Nolan's The Odyssey (+ IMAX); Cut Off
FRI 24	Heads of State; Untitled DCU
FRI 31	Spider-Man: Brand New Day

AUGUST 2026

FRI 7	Once Upon a Time in a Cinema
FRI 14	Flowervale Street; PAW Patrol 3: The Dino Movie
FRI 21	Mutiny; The Bride!
FRI 28	Crime 101; Outcome

SEPTEMBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 4	Conjuring: Last Rites
FRI 11	Resident Evil reboot
FRI 18	The Black Phone 2
FRI 25	Tron: Ares (+ IMAX)

OCTOBER 2026 • PREVIEW

FRI 16	Untitled Christopher McQuarrie thriller
FRI 23	Frankenstein (del Toro)

On the sporting calendar

MAY 2026		JULY 2026	
THU 14	PGA Championship begins (Golf)	4–26 JUL	Tour de France (Cycling)
WED 20	UEFA Europa League Final	SUN 5	British Grand Prix, Silverstone
SAT 23	EFL Championship Play-off Final, Wembley	16–19 JUL	The Open Championship (Golf)
SUN 24	Premier League final day (all 10 games, 3pm BST)	18–26 JUL	World Matchplay Darts, Blackpool
24 MAY – 7 JUN	French Open (Tennis)	23 JUL – 2 AUG	Commonwealth Games, Glasgow
THU 28	Premier League Darts Finals Night	AUGUST 2026	
SAT 30	UEFA Champions League Final	W/C 10	Hundred & T20 Blast climax (Cricket)
JUNE 2026		SAT 15	Premier League season begins (2026/27)
THU 4	NBA Finals begin	22–23	Belgian Grand Prix (F1)
11 JUN – 19 JUL	FIFA World Cup (USA / Canada / Mexico)		
11–14 JUN	World Cup of Darts		
12 JUN – 5 JUL	ICC Women's T20 World Cup (England & Wales)		
18–21 JUN	U.S. Open (Golf)		
29 JUN – 12 JUL	Wimbledon		